

The Transcendent Calling of Marriage Genesis 2:18-25

And Extended Introduction: Three Aspects to *The Demise of Marriage*

1. The Demise of Marriage in Divorce: Ecosystem that is unfriendly to thriving marriages...

We all know, that over 50% of marriage end in divorce... but has it become so common knowledge that we are no longer moved by this statistic... what was meant to be entered into as so high a calling as to warrant a vow of poverty ("better or for poorer, richer or poorer, in sickness or in health, until death do us part"...) is being torn apart OVER 50% of the time, often times leaving in its wake all sorts of social and human tragedies...

Why? At very least, it is because every marriage is born within a social ecosystem that is inherently unfertile to healthy marriage—an ecosystem that is characterized by selfish and expressive individualism...

As noted then by Robert Bellah,

Marriage becomes a context for expressive individualism, or a "life style enclave... for in believing in love, we American's believe in the self. The love that must hold us together is rooted in the vicissitudes of our subjectivity.... Love is redefined as self-knowledge and self-realization

How should we respond?

NOT—as so many Christians do—by idolizing marriage

E.g. Rather than challenging the ecosystem itself--- as driven after the principle of individualism, we too often merely co-opt the ecosystem and treat marriage as sacred, but as a means of self-fulfillment or self-expression... all in the name of God!

Too often, the problem in marriages is TOO high of expectations concerning what marriage can and is meant to do. When we idolize marriage or the marriage partner, marriage becomes a means of self-love and self-gratification, self expression, rather than a calling to love one another as a means of serving God and even society as a covenant institution. The result of creating an idol out of marriage and/or our marriage partner is to then "need" our marriage and or marriage partner for the sake of finding that which only God can give through Christ. If according to Augustine "our hearts are restless until they find their rest in God" it is too often the case that couples get married thinking their restless hearts will find rest in a spouse—with *tragic consequences*. The result is a marriage characterized more by manipulation than ministry one to the other in order to satisfy our craving hearts that can only be satisfied by God. In short, to idolize marriage is to ignore the sacred purpose of marriage which is, ironically, to direct us to salvation as accomplished and applied by Christ, rather than to become our salvation, as so many pop love songs seem to suggest.

Therefore, we need to rediscover the *calling* of marriage, which is exactly why we need to read and study again Gen. 2!

We will discover that marriage as a *calling*, ultimately less about us and more about God and his higher purposes for marriage for the good of humanity and redemption. We enter into marriage the way one enters into other such "callings" wherein it is recognized that one is committing ones self to a "noble dream" that is intrinsic to the institution we are called to serve less anything about us. Every

authentic calling has a noble dream that makes whatever sacrifices and sufferings that may occur as a cost worthy of the calling!

2. Demise of Marriage in the Perversion of Sex

The popularization and perhaps more significantly, the normalization of Sex Outside of Marriage has been well documented! Even as sex is intrinsically marital in nature, the sacred "rite of marriage" is more and more being normalized as the "rite of romance" - all the more exotic if outside of marriage even, the more spontaneous the better!

Illus. I grew up with James Bond... and a whole host of other such depictions where "the good guys" always get it! Almost every love story end not in marriage but in sex...

What all this represents is the materialization of sex—or better, the sensualization of sex... E.g. sex is defined merely as sensual pleasure, bereft of its covenantal, emotional, relational even truly romantic aspects as celebrated in Scripture.

How should we respond?

NOT— as so many Christians do, by turning the topic of sex and sexual intimacy over to the world... not by treating sex as an improper world, if not even a dirty word. NOT by losing the romance of sex.. **not by talking about sex ONLY under the topic of abstinence!** (asceticism).

Rather, Christians, of all people ought to have the highest and most romantic view of sex--- A materialistic or ascetic view of sex are both the byproducts of idolizing sex in our society and can wreak havoc on the otherwise beauty of sex in marriage-- one that is so beautiful, so transcendent even, one that celebrates sex and enjoys sex as the sacred rite of marriage to be sure! Sex, as the covenant ritual of marriage, needs to be rediscovered, experienced and even celebrated, as it is so beautifully celebrated in the Song of Solomon.. (and even here, Christians have been slow to acknowledge that the Song of Solomon IS about romance in marriage, even if only secondarily it may also typologically point to a greater romance between heaven and earth, God and humanity via the redemption accomplished by Christ.

Therefore, we need to rediscover and celebrate the *sacred ritual of marriage* as to transcend the low level romance of this world! We need to celebrate sex as it is meant to be celebrated, not merely talk about abstaining from sex!

3. The demise of marriage by means of Civil Unions—Gay Marriages

We are of course all aware of the legislative actions and movements that are directed toward the legalization of same-sex union, even marriages! And yes from a Christian point of view, we still hold to the idea that marriage is inherently bi-sexual as to require the two sexes! And of course, as it is all too publicly being played out in one of our sister denominations!

How then should we respond?

NOT—with hate and self-righteousness as it too often the response of evangelical Christians!

Example:

"It is devilish and satanic. It comes directly from the pit of hell. It is an idea sponsored by Satan himself and being executed by his followers and adherents who have infiltrated the church."

Louis Green, African Christian Democratic Party in South Africa, "African Anglicans Vent Anger at Gay Bishop"
NYT 11/3/03

What's wrong with this statement?

1. Practically: What person struggling with homosexuality would dare seek this bishop's pastoral care and help, or go to this bishop's church? To be sure, there is much wrong about the above quote, not least of which is that it can't possibly accomplish anything good!
2. Biblically, it is too selective... the quote seems to characterize homosexuality as somehow uniquely "devilish" THIS JUST ISN'T SO!

Yes, and for the record, we do believe that homosexuality is A sin, but according to Romans 1:29-31, it is listed not as a greater or lesser sin as compared to any other sin, but as one of many sins that ultimately warrants God's condemnation of those who participate in any sin if without the grace of God as revealed in Christ.

More specifically, homosexuality, in that it is ultimately a sin against marriage and a perversion of sex in marriage, is no less of a perversion, no more, than any other perversion of sex and marriage!

Again, our response ought to be to reaffirm what is right about love in marriage between a man and a woman, even what is lost in same sex unions and marriage, how this love can NOT be duplicated in same sex union/marriage!

The question may be raised, might a same-sex relationship be blessed in God's sight because the "gay" or lesbian couple love each other?

Pannenberg asked the question in a different way, "Can love ever be sinful?," and then answered with an unequivocal yes. "The entire tradition of Christian doctrine teaches that there is such a thing as inverted, perverted love," Pannenberg said. "Human beings are created for love, as creatures of the God who is Love. And yet that divine appointment is corrupted whenever people turn away from God or love things more than God."

WE will want to talk about Homosexuality, then, is A form of idolatry (NOT THE FORM), whereby God is exchanged for the temporal and carnal pleasures of this life. More specifically, as per the idolatry of homosexuality, the marriage union between two sexes is exchanged for mere self-centered sensual enjoyment of the sexual faculties, and the male/female model is exchanged for one in which one worships an image of oneself through same-sex activity.

3. Spirituality—the above quote I think reflects an even deeper problem... e.g. the problem of self-righteousness as an idolatry!

Explain:

Why the anger? What does anger reflect about us?

1. Anger means that we have lost sight of the gospel—e.g. that our religion is a friend to sinners ,not enemies... Jesus was the friend of sinners...

Matt. 9:10

And as he sat at dinner in the house, many tax collectors and sinners came and were sitting with him and his disciples. **11** When the Pharisees saw this, they said to his disciples, "Why does your teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?"

Matt. 9:13

Go and learn what this means, 'I desire mercy, not sacrifice.' For I have come to call not the righteous but sinners."

2. Anger exposes that we cherish an idol, even as this idol is evidently being threatened by something we are angered about..

For instance, perhaps in a moralistic way of thinking, we have taken great pride, confidence, assurance from the fact that we are "straight" it has made you feel as if you are not so bad, that God doesn't look upon you and frown so much, etc. etc. Do you hear it, this is idolatry—idolatry is anything that gives us a false sense of self-righteousness, assurance as to God's love and acceptance, etc.

E.g. if you really knew yourself in a Christian way, you would know yourself to be wholly sinful, more so than you ever dared think! We are and continue to have within us indwelling sin of the likes that would surely bring us to despair of any hope in god's acceptance and love, which is why we put ourselves at the mercy of God's grace!

1Tim. 1:15

The saying is sure and worthy of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners—of whom I am the foremost.

And so again, our response to homosexuality ought to be less about condemning people who struggle with it, as to bring them in with all the rest of us "sinners" into the grace of the gospel no less so than we would bring all people as related to all sins to the grace of the gospel by faith alone, even as then we will need to restore our vision for marriage as to include necessarily two sexes.. again why we need to read and study Gen. 2!

So then, however the demise of marriage is actually happening, whether through the idolization of marriage, the perversion of sex or same sex unions/marriages, our great need is to rediscover the marriage institution as it is uniquely designed by God for humanity, and for what purpose as then to require what elements!

This is when, albeit after this long introduction, we turn to our passage...

Exposition:

I. A Suitable Helper?!

18 *And the Lord God said, (it is) not good for man to be alone. I will make him a helper "suitable" him.*

18- Against the sevenfold refrain "and God saw that it was good", it is here "not good" for man to dwell alone.

With all the splendor, with all the beauty, with all that God had already done-- the passage here makes explicit that all was still not right!

What was missing?

A helper...

Importance of a "helper" so as to accomplish the mandate is clear...

Elsewhere, "helper" can refer to divine assistance,

Gen. 49:25 By the God of your father who will help you, And by the Almighty who will bless you With blessings of heaven above, Blessings of the deep that lies beneath, Blessings of the breasts and of the womb.

Pss. 30:10 Hear, O Lord, and have mercy on me; Lord, be my helper"

Pss. 121:1 I will lift up my eyes to the hills--From whence comes my help? 2 My help comes from the Lord, Who made heaven and earth.

Military aid (Isa.30:5, Ezek.12:14, etc.

I.e. Assumes that the strength./ability of one party is inadequate in itself so as to need assistance or deliverance...

Here-- what kind of help?

Note vs. 19-20-- where Adam is depicted in his governing role of naming all the animals

19 Out of the ground the Lord God formed every beast of the field and every bird of the air, and brought them to Adam to see what he would call them. And whatever Adam called each living creature, that was its name. 20 So Adam gave names to all cattle, to the birds of the air, and to every beast of the field.

And yet again it is stated-- (vs. 20b)*But for Adam there was not found a helper comparable to him.*

1. The picture is that Adam was overwhelmed with his duties as a governor of creation and needed help... the wife is here described as a helper which would seem to put it in this context of human vocation and calling-- that two are better than one so to speak..

2. But note also that in all this parade of creation, "there was still not found..."

The need for a helper made all the more evident by the fact that it is concluded only after every other creature was inspected and named...

Moses here puts creation in suspense-- as the great king seems to be searching for a companion-- and yet nothing else was suitable!

(How often we think our jobs, our work, our various creation duties could be a sufficient companion for us, but it is not!-- Perhaps you are like me-- that if there is tension in the marriage, there is something profound missing in life itself-- no matter how things are going at work!-- there was nothing suitable for a helper)

What exactly was missing though-- a helper "comparable, suitable"...

Actually the word is "opposite"

(for those married, very instructive indeed (:

Gen. 21:16 Then she went and sat down across from him at a distance of about a bowshot; for she said to herself, "Let me not see the death of the boy." So she sat opposite him, and lifted her voice and wept.

Literally, the Hebrew word "suitable" can mean "in the sight of", "in front of" even "opposite to." In Gen. 2:18, it is used with the preposition "like to, as." The compound phrase "opposite him" refers then to a "matching" kind of relationship. Therefore, some translations have interpreted this as related to the complementarity of women to men, such as the ESV "fit to" or, as noted in the ESV, "corresponding to." Perhaps more insightful than a strict word study even is its use in context, especially vs. 20 of chapter 2, where it is used to describe the women in relation to man in context with his vocational role of exercising authority over creation in naming them. (which in the ancient Near East was an exercise of authority). The man was in some sense "inadequate" to accomplish the task such as to require a "helper." The point here is merely to say that the woman, was created to "help" Adam in his vocational activity, not to merely benefit from his vocational activity. Vocational speaking, the text gives no indication that women were not actively involved in a capacity "comparable" to man in the creation mandate.

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Interestingly, this seems to be Paul's commentary in 1 Tim.3:12-13,

I do not permit a woman to have authority over a man... for adam was formed first and then Eve...

So here, the "helper" is someone to complement rather than compete toward accomplishing the creation mandate for man to govern creation as creature king unto God...

One more observation-- Man seems totally incapable of fixing the dilemma himself. What he needed was not something he could provide for within himself either... -- He is without a SUITABLE helper.. he is without a complement!

But a compliment for what exactly? Here, we need then to review the context of marriage that is given to us by Genesis 1-2!

II. In what sense then is the Wife “suitable” or “complimentary” to the husband... e.g. what would be lost if you did not have both the sexes represented in marriage?

First, the wife is uniquely suited to help Adam fulfill the *imago dei* in the world.

Gen.1:26, *So God created humans in His image, in the image of God He created them male and female he created them.*

According to Gen. 1:27, God made humanity for the purpose of reflecting his image, an image that is both male and female *in union together*. The dual aspects of God’s gender is nowhere more clearly affirmed than in the union of a man and woman in marriage, even as the vocational responsibilities of marriage are added to this sacred relationship, most especially as applied to procreation in Genesis 1:28. To be sure, there is much about sexuality that is still mysterious to us, but whatever it does mean to be “man” vs. “women,” it is assumed that both are required to image God on earth, even as both are assumed in procreation to the glory of God.

Yes, it is an notable irony, that in a social context that rightly wants to rediscover the importance of a two gender conception of God and the equality of the sexes that some would then reduce marriage to a single gender institution to the detriment of the image of God and human complementariness.

Second, the wife is uniquely suited to help Adam fulfill his vocational calling as concerning the cultural and cultic mandate!.

Gen. 2:15

The LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to *till it and keep it*.

As to anticipate 2:18 and the creation of a “helper”, the immediate context is related to help in two areas “till... keep”

English obscures the true meaning of these words, as:

- ✓ “till”—means “cultivate” as reference to cultural mandate
- ✓ “keep” means “guard” as reference to the cultic duties of the priest especially as for the temple, even as this is used in Gen.3:24 to describe the role of the guardian cherubim as depicted on the temple curtain guarding the entrance into the Holy of Holies!

Notice then, in Gen. 1, how the vocational commission is given to both the man and women together “them”

Gen. 1:28

God blessed them, and God said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the air and over every living thing that moves upon the earth.”

The implications of all of this is huge as especially related to “roles”

E.g. Albeit in typically embryonic fashion in Genesis, the male/female constituents in marriage are shown to be essential in order to fulfill the vocational mandate given to humanity, even as the male and female are shown to be “co-equal” in their “office” of both “image of God” and “believer”

E.g. in so far as these two vocational roles correspond to persons as cultural and cultic persons, it corresponds to the offices held by both women and men as civil and spiritual servants.

What this means, but implication, is that whatever other roles men and women will have in marriage (as per the third way that the wife is “suitable” for man below noted), it is not the case that women are not co-equal in status and function in her office as a civil servant and a believer..

What this means is that the wife shares in her role as wife, in the privileges, rights and responsibilities in both the civil and spiritual spheres!!! More specifically, it is no less the responsibility for wives to be mature Christians as men, and to express this in the home as per teaching, instruction, praying, etc.. even as it is no less the responsibility for wives to be mature civil servants as men, and to express this in whatever way it is deemed appropriate given the gifts and training of the couple as for the common good.. IT is not the women’s place necessarily to “stay at home” even if it IS the parents responsibility to be committed to the home however this is worked out in terms of who stays home when, etc.

In short, There is then a vocational aspect to marriage, in so far as there is a “work” to be done for the glory of God and the benefit of humanity that is accomplished by the complementariness of husband and wife working together. This is not only satisfied in the procreation aspects of the mandate and parenting, but also in so far as the family becomes the institutional “germ seed” for both the historical development of the church and state in Biblical history. It can be said that the grace and law aspects of the church and state respectively require that which can be given ideally through the family as formed out of the marriage of husband and wife. As once noted by Samuel Davies,

The great Author of our nature, who has made us sociable creatures, has instituted various societies among mankind, both civil and religious, and joined them together by the various bonds of relation. The first and radical society is that of a family, which is the nursery of the church and state. This was the society instituted in paradise in the state of innocence, when the indulgent Creator, finding that it was not good for a man, a sociable creature, to be alone, formed a helpmeet for him and united them in the endearing bonds of the conjugal relation. From thence, the human race was propagated; and when multiplied, it was formed into civil governments and ecclesiastical assemblies...

Therefore, in so far as the family is the mother of all social institutions in our society, one can rightly say that so goes the family, so goes the health and well being of a civilization! IT IS A BIG DEAL and with far reaching implications that families are generated and

preserved, as by the vows taken to initiate a family witnessed even by God!

Third there is yet another way that the wife is uniquely suited to help the man in fulfilling God's purpose in marriage... as then related to a redemptive typology or "role play"

Gen.2:24, "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two will become one flesh."

Of course this vs. references "sex" as it is the sacred ritual of marriage with respect to "the two becoming one flesh." But what is this sacred ritual all about ultimately?

The apostle Paul leaves no doubt as to the ultimate meaning of this statement, when after quoting this passage in Eph. 5:31, he declares in verse 32, *This is a great mystery, and I am applying it to Christ and the church*. The context of this statement is of course Paul's exhortations to husbands and wives concerning their sacred roles one to the other—roles that are again envisioned from the very beginning of the marriage institution, albeit in germ seed fashion.

How then does the sacred typology of marriage as reference to Christ and the church work out exactly... In the Eph. Context, it is clearly related to the roles of wives and husband related to Christ's sacrificial love for the church and the churches giving herself in trust and submission to Christ in response—this is further spelled out even as related to the Trinity in 1Cor.10

3 But I want you to understand that Christ is the head of every man, and the husband is the head of his wife, and God is the head of Christ.

Again, clearly co-equality of husband and wife are in view, lest Christ be not "co=equal" to the Father as clearly taught in Scripture... but co-equality is not the same as the same in authority...

This is also albeit vaguely referenced in Gen. 2 another way as interpreted by Paul again:

Gen. 2:18

Then the LORD God said, "It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper as his partner..." **22** And the rib that the LORD God had taken from the man he made into a woman and brought her to the man.

As then to the ultimate vocation given to marriage, the scriptures portray the union of husband and wife in terms of a sacred and typological "role-play." This role-play is vaguely alluded to at creation when Adam was established first in the order of creation, followed then by the creation of women as a helper that was then "brought to" him. E.g. her role was in a subordinate capacity as to help Adam, even as she was brought to Adam as noted in 1Tim.2:13 to this effect. Again, The purpose of this role-play is later exposed when after the fall and God's subsequent promise to bring forth redemption by the seed of a women, Adam exercises his authority in

naming her “Eve” or “mother of life” in so far as this expressed the redemptive promise to be accomplished by God as initiated by the birth of Seth and ultimately in the birth of Christ by the “seed of a women” by miraculous conception.

Therefore, throughout redemptive history under both the Old and New Covenants, marriage is used as an analogy of God's covenant relationship with his church, a living paradigm depicting the redemptive relationship between God and his bride-people. (Hosea 2:18-20, Ezekiel 16:8, Mt. 19:4-6, 1 Cor. 11:3, Eph. 5:22-24)

AS this is all portrayed in the marriage roles, again it should be stated that even as the women is co-equal in her office of believer and civil servant, as to then enjoy the benefits and to enjoin upon her the responsibilities of both, she is to do this assuming a posture of submission relative to her husband! E.g. again, it is not that she can't take leadership roles, teach, pray, initiate, whatever—but that as she does this, she does this in recognizing and respecting the role-play wherein Christ is glorified in and for the church. She can teach/lead in family worship, but under the authority of her husband as to defer to him

So then, when the congregation stands to give homage to the glory of a bride, beautifully adorned, in her procession to her eagerly awaiting groom, so we give homage to what transcends all of this in the procession of Christ church down through history to the loving embrace of her savior and husband Jesus Christ. The role-play has nothing at all to do with anything intrinsic to maleness or femaleness, at least in so far as the scripture is concerned, but as related to the order of creation that establishes a typological relationship between a husband and wife that is to direct their roles for the sake of bearing witness to Christ and His bride, the church. Even as Jesus Christ himself cloths his bride with the unconditional love and righteous works given to the church for her sanctification before God and received by faith alone so too the husband is commanded to love his wife as Christ loved the church, even giving himself to her as to sanctify her (typologically) by his righteous deeds on her behalf, even as the wife is commanded to submit herself to her husband as unto the Lord, receiving his leadership and sacrificial love as to role play the faith of the church to Christ (see then Ephesians 5:22ff). In summary, we should notice how Paul explicitly applies Genesis The whole thing is sacred in so far as it uniquely expresses and dramatically gives witness to the salvation plan of God.

THE CLASSIC VOWS OF MARRIAGE BETWEEN A HUSBAND AND WIFE DIRECT US TO YET ANOTHER VOW, ONE THAT WILL BE KEPT PERFECTLY AND UNCONDITIONALLY BY CHRIST FOR YOU AND FOR ME!

Christ said before he departed into heaven, *I am with you until the end of this age*, where then we know that he will return and be “married” ultimately and eternally to his bride, those saved by grace through faith alone. And to be sure, he made good on his promise “till death do us part” even as he continues to make good on his promise as he *fills all in all*.

Marriage was considered “sacred” in its redemptive function meant to point people to God's plan of salvation. The dramatic role-play climaxes at the marriage of Christ to the church in salvation as gloriously described in Revelations 19:6-7.

Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and be glad and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb

has come, and his bride has made herself ready; and to her it has been granted to be clothed with fine linen, bright and pure"-- for the fine linen is the righteous judgments on her behalf, And the angel said to me, "Write this: Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb."

Summary:

Indeed, marriage is sacred, as for a full expression of the *imago dei*, as for the full accomplishment of the cultural and cultic mandates as pertaining to the office of civil and spiritual servants of God, and as for the full typological expression of Christ and the Church for the salvation of the world..

It is sacred and therefore it is a *calling*:

IV. Marriage as a Calling, as then properly initiated with the taking of vows, even the vows of poverty.

Someone asked me yesterday about the origin of the classic vows in marriage... "for richer or for poorer, in sickness or in health, for better or for worse... till death do us part"

I honestly don't know where these vows originated, other than that they are in the Anglican Book of Common Prayer...

But what I do know is that they are perfectly suited to Genesis

23 Then the man said,
"This at last is bone of my bones
and flesh of my flesh; this one shall be called Woman,
for out of Man this one was taken."

Better and the man "vowed"! For the language is clearly vow language as compared to other usages in the Hebrew Bible! when Adam made his solemn affirmation that "this is now bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh" it was not some inane observation as if God needed to be informed concerning Eve's origins. Rather these words constituted a solemn oath of covenant faithfulness-- an abbreviated way of saying "may this woman be to me as my own body-- and because of this, should I ever fail to love and care for her as my own body, thereby breaking the covenant bond between us, I hereby solemnly invite God to make it hurt me like bones and flesh being wrenched out of my body." That this statement was a covenantal oath is further demonstrated by the use of the phrase "bone of my bones" in other similar oath taking ceremonies in the Ancient Near East as depicted in Genesis 29:14. (See also the use of this formula in Judges 9:2, 2 Samuel 19:12-13) This formula then informs the NT teaching that husband are to love their wives as their own bodies. (Eph.5:21-33)

24 Therefore a man leaves his father and his mother and clings to his wife, and they become one flesh.

AGAIN,

the covenantal language in this word! This is not just descriptive language, but also language that places this relationship into a covenant context of binding vows! For instance, when Scripture says that a man shall "cleave" to his wife (Gen.2:24), it is using a covenant term used elsewhere to express the way the Israelites were to cleave with affection and loyalty to the Lord. (Dt.10:20, 11:22, 13:4, Josh.22:5, etc.) To "cleave" is to be joined to another in a way that assumes the interest of the other as forever my interest. It is something of what Paul meant when he says in Eph. 5:28 *In the same way, husbands should love their wives as they do their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself*

become one flesh-- Sexuality as a sacred ritual is meant to symbolize a greater theological truth—e.g. that it is "man and women" in so far as they are a good fit for the purpose of a) satisfying the vocational mandate and b) satisfying the imago dei... e.g. we want to affirm that sexuality, all sexuality, is exclusively marital by nature and is exclusively designed to be the sacred covenant ritual that both symbolically and effectually initiates and consummates the marriage covenant. Second, we want to reaffirm that the meaning of marriage derivative of its relation to God and God's plan of salvation.

APPLICATIONS:

1. Against the ecosystem of individualism that destroys marriage, we need to reaffirm that marriage is not about the self, but ultimately about God and his redemptive purposes.

if you are married, consider whatever troubles and hardships you may be experiencing in the context of this sacred calling, remember your vow of poverty, even as you remember that there is something so noble, so transcendently special that you are accomplishing in your marriage, that it makes whatever hardship you must endure worth it.. and then, take a marriage enrichment weekend.. (e-mail me and I will give you some materials to assist you in this if you want). And if you are having a hard time communicating and working through your issues, get help now! You are not alone and this is exactly what Christ has given you through his church. Lets sit down and talk together before things go too far!

2. Against the perversion of marriage in the perversion of sex, we need to reaffirm that sex in marriage is the sacred covenant ritual that both symbolizes and functions to affect the holistic union, body and soul, that exists between a husband and wife, even as this union is meant to point to a greater and more ultimate union between Christ and his church as depicted by yet another sacred ritual of the Lord's supper.

If you are not married, do not have sex! It will only pervert its sacred and yes even romantic aspects. Preserve yourself and this holy rite for your marriage.. do not let hollywood fool you, whatever happens that so call dramatic evening, will be spoiled and soiled by the time you wake up the next morning—YOU WILL REGRET IT.

3. Against the perversion of marriage in same-sex unions/marriage, we need to reaffirm how it is that the complementariness of two sexes in marriage are meant to explain the complementariness of human with divine as made possible by Christ, who as one being was both God and human to reconcile the two together by grace..

And if you are a person who struggles with same sex fantasies or sins, do not hang your head around here, you are not alone, you are not condemned, you are not rejected, you are in place that believes in the gospel for you no less, no more, than it believes in the gospel for people who struggle with other sins. There is no distinction.. we are all sinners and we are all people who need God's grace... but get help as well.. do not live in isolation- e-mail me and I will be happy to give you some materials and direct you to some support that you may need.

IN short, if we have learned nothing at all from this sermon today, might we learn how carefully and even fearfully God planned for your salvation, even as to write it into the very fabric of creation itself, and into the fabric of Creations first institution, the family.

Individualism in self-fulfillment or self-expression, sex outside of marriage, or the perversion of sex as between the same sex— whatever possible short lived pleasures any of this might bring PALES in comparison to the eternal and life giving grace that was planned for you in Christ...

Might we then be led by this sermon to believe in this salvation as accomplished by Christ, to believe in his steadfast and unconditional vows as fulfilled by Christ that we might enjoy god forever!

And do we join partaking of the feast of heaven, even the marriage supper of the lamb!